

Agenda Setting in American Political Campaigning

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Although the channels of communication during political campaigns have changed dramatically over the history of the United States, the flow of public communication has been vital from the beginning. In what is arguably the most historically important political campaign of all for the United States, building political support for the independence of the British colonies in America, the extensive efforts of the Committees of Correspondence and the perspectives of colonial newspapers played major roles.

By 1772, there were more than a hundred Committees of Correspondence in Massachusetts alone, and in 1773, the committee affiliated with the House of Burgesses in Virginia initiated efforts to create Committees of Correspondence throughout the colonies. In the colonial newspapers, the salience of place names changed dramatically in the decades preceding the Declaration of Independence. In the decade immediately prior to the Declaration of Independence, a third of the geographic names appearing in the colonial press referred to North America alone. In the final two years, 1774 and 1775, fully half of the geographic citations referred to North America alone.

Even more pertinent to the idea of an agenda-setting role of the press in achieving political consensus, symbols referring to the American colonies as a single unit increased significantly after 1763. After that date, about a fourth of all the American symbols in the newspapers referred to the colonies as a single, common unit. This geographical agenda of the 18th-century colonial press helped build the cultural and political identity of a new nation (McCombs 2014, 35–36).

In the century following independence, newspapers played a central role in election campaigns. Most editors made their political preferences very clear, frequently in rather vitriolic language. The rise of “objective journalism” in the latter part of the 19th century ameliorated the tone to some degree, but daily newspapers remained the mainstay of political communication until the 1920s. That decade saw the birth of radio broadcasting and an abundance of new channels for news and political speeches. Most cities and towns now had several radio stations and two or more daily newspapers. As the link between “the world outside and the pictures in our heads”—to use Walter Lippmann’s phrase in *Public Opinion* (1922)—the news media now had the advantage of mass communication channels that saturated the country.

Lippmann’s phrase took on almost literal meaning with the rapid diffusion of television in the mid-20th century. Live coverage of the Democrat and Republican national conventions and the first TV political ads during a national election both occurred in 1972, and political campaigns were forever altered. As we move into this new century, the niche between the massive diffusion of political ads on television and interpersonal communication about political campaigns and the candidates has been populated by political messages via Facebook, Twitter, and other social media. The reach and frequency of political communication during election campaigns is at an historic high.

Agenda setting offers a parsimonious theoretical perspective for analyzing the role of these various channels of political communication in political campaigns nationally and locally. At the core of agenda-setting theory are the metaphoric concept of agendas and the transfer of salience from one agenda to the other. In considering the agenda-setting roles of various political communicators, it is important to keep in mind that in the context of agenda-setting theory, an *agenda* is a neutral descriptive term for a set of elements that define an agenda, not the use of the term in the advocacy sense of *having an agenda*. At the heart of agenda-setting theory is the transfer of salience from media agendas to the public agenda. As we shall see, this transfer of salience can encompass a considerable range of elements from the media agenda. However, the media agenda and public agenda link is not the only pair of agendas that have been investigated. In political campaigns, the transfer of salience—or, at least, the attempted transfer of salience—from the agendas of political campaigns to the news media and the transfer of salience from the agendas of political campaigns to the public are equally important communication processes. In turn, it is essential to consider the consequences of these various agenda-setting channels for citizens’ attitudes, opinions, and observable behavior. All of these agenda-setting relationships will be explored in detail in this chapter. And to bring our discussion up-to-date, there will be special emphasis on where the social media fit in this theoretical perspective.

Competitive Processes of Campaign Agenda Formation

At the core of the agenda-setting process is a nexus of interactions among the media agenda, a variety of political agendas, and the public agenda. After the first wave of studies examined the impact of the media agenda on the public agenda, scholars in the early 1980s began to investigate the initial process by which an issue climbs to the news agenda, raising the question, "Who sets the media's agenda?" Because of the very limited carrying capacity of the news arena, a wide variety of issue entrepreneurs compete to win a place on the news agenda. This dynamic and competitive process is sometimes called *agenda formation* (Brandenburg 2002; Scheufele 1999). Studies on the agenda-formation process have illuminated "the political-media complex," a constantly evolving relationship between politics and the media and the ways in which both relate to the public (Swanson 1997).

Since the 1990s, the term *CNN effects* has been used to raise concerns about the increasing role of media as a policy agenda setter, especially in the realm of U.S. diplomacy and foreign relations (Livingston 1997), yet few empirical investigations have supported this argument. In fact, it is still highly controversial whether or under what circumstances the mass media can determine the political agenda. In their comprehensive analysis of relevant studies, Walgrave and Van Aelst (2006) suggest that the relationship between the media and the political agenda is contingent on various conditions, such as the kinds of issues covered, the specific media outlet, the type of coverage, and political contexts. Among other factors, political contexts, especially the time period when politics and media interactions take place, significantly matter to the agenda-formation dynamics. In routine political times, various political actors, such as the president, government officials, Parliament, political parties, and the like, have been identified as important agenda setters (Wanta 1991; Wanta and Foote 1994; Wanta et al. 1989). The short campaign period before Election Day, however, may be significantly different from routine periods (Walgrave and Van Aelst 2006). In election times, the process of agenda formation consists mainly of campaign and media interactions (Semetko et al. 1991; Tedesco 2001). Campaign studies have thus focused on the following questions: Are political campaigns successful in setting their own issues on the news agenda? Or do they just reflect the media agenda or try to ride the wave following what is prioritized by the media?

Most of all, the dynamics of campaign agenda formation may vary depending on larger political and media surroundings. For instance, Semetko et al. (1991) proposed that the U.S. news media function as an independent agenda setter, successfully shaping the political agenda through their largely commercialized media systems. By contrast, the British news media, which occupy a more public service-oriented environment, mainly play the role

of agenda amplifier by following the agendas advocated by political elites. According to Walgrave and Van Aelst (2006), however, most prior studies indicate that the media's political agenda-setting power is minimal in elections in Western democracies. That is, the political agenda leads the media agenda during campaign periods while "the media's impact on candidates' and parties' agendas is limited or even absent" (96).

Meanwhile, in the contemporary media landscape, the roles played by the media in mediating the relationship between the political sector and the voting public are taking on ever greater importance. This phenomenon, conceptualized as "mediatization," is the process by which "politics [has] increasingly lost its autonomy, [has] become dependent in its central function on mass media" (Mazzoleni and Schulz 1999, 250). The term *mediatization* implies that the media's power to intrude on the political process grows stronger in an environment where citizens' partisan loyalty and political engagement are steadily weakened. As a result, the media are able to extend the reach of candidates and political parties, ultimately helping them influence the overall electoral agenda-setting process (Petrocik, Benoit, and Hansen 2003). Campaigns are thus able to "regulate the salience of issues, by way of that, the vote" (Brandenberg 2002, 35). In essence, the media's main function in political campaigns may be to transplant changes in salience in the campaign agenda in the public's mind and, by so doing, influence citizens' choices.

In that regard, the ability of political campaigns to create a unique and competitive agenda of issues and candidate attributes and, consequently, shape the news agenda is critical to electoral fortunes. Political candidates have so far been relatively successful in setting their own agenda for the news through various types of political advertising, particularly television ads (Boyle 2001; Roberts and McCombs 1994). However, in the wake of digitalization and diversification of communication channels, online channels of political campaigns now function as main sources of electoral news. Early on, official campaign Web sites played a central role (Ku, Kaid, and Pfau 2003), but more customized and personalized forms of online channels are currently being utilized to deliver candidates' own agendas of policy issues and attributes (Hermans and Vergeer 2012). E-campaigning is becoming an important source for traditional election news. Additionally, e-channels increasingly operate as a direct route for politicians to interact with ordinary citizens without the mediation of mainstream media. Social networking sites, such as Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube, have been especially effective in communicating with relatively disengaged voters, as evidenced in the 2008 Obama campaign (Kushin and Yamamoto 2010).

Likewise, the dynamics of intermedia agenda setting are being transformed. Previous studies have reported that the national elite media, such as the *New York Times*, the Associated Press, the national television networks,

and a handful of other major newspapers, often initiate issues for all the other media, producing a highly redundant news agenda across the nation. That is, there is a spillover effect from the national quality press to the other media in intermedia agenda setting (Habermas 2006). The emergence of new, alternative forms of online journalism, however, is changing the interactive patterns among news outlets. Studies have shown that online news outlets and traditional elite media reciprocally influence each other (Lee 2007; Woodly 2008). While the intermedia agenda-setting effect of traditional media still remains significant, there is accumulated evidence on the spillover effects from the online-based alternative media to the established media (Weaver and Choi, forthcoming).

In conclusion, the processes of campaign agenda formation are becoming progressively more complicated and dynamic; new players are coming onto the scene and actively interacting with traditional agenda setters. The media's role in mediating between political campaigns and the voting public continues to be significant, yet there are increasing numbers of direct channels between the campaign agenda and the public agenda.

Shaping the Public's Perceptions of Issues and Candidates

All of these interactions among the political agenda, the media agenda, and the public agenda can be examined in terms of three distinct types of agenda-setting effects. The Chapel Hill study introduced what are now referred to as basic or first-level agenda-setting effects (McCombs and Shaw 1972), the transfer of *issue salience* from the news media to the public agenda. The central hypothesis in Chapel Hill was that the pattern of coverage in the news media influences the public's perceptions of the importance of those issues. Specifically, the rank order of issues based on how much coverage they received in the news over a period of time influenced the rank order of those issues among the public. In Chapel Hill, the rank order of the five major issues in the 1968 U.S. presidential campaign on the media agenda corresponded almost perfectly with the rank order of the public's responses to a survey question asking them what they regarded as the key issues of the day. Most of the early research on agenda setting followed this path, examining the correspondence between the frequency of issues on the media agenda with the frequency of those issues on the public agenda. In other words, the mass media set the agenda of issues for a political campaign by influencing the salience of these issues among voters.

To this day, the majority of agenda-setting research is focused on issue agendas. In terms of this specific focus, the definition of agenda setting is issues that are prominent in the news become prominent in the public mind. More specifically, the strength of this influence can be measured with a correlation

statistic, and Wanta and Ghanem's (2006) meta-analysis of agenda-setting studies found an average correlation of 0.53 between the media and public agendas, with most studies falling between 0.47 and 0.59.

However, the media agenda consists of far more than an agenda of issues. During election campaigns, key elements on the agenda are the candidates themselves, especially in primary elections where numerous candidates from the same party, who are frequently unknown to most voters, compete for attention. For their campaigns, achieving *name recognition* is often the primary goal in the early days of the election period. In other words, the campaigns seek to influence the salience of their candidate on the public agenda. Beyond issues and candidates, the political, media, and public agendas can be defined in many other ways. The salience of political parties, social movements, and many other political actors also can be studied.

In abstract theoretical terms, the first level of agenda setting consists of agendas of objects. Here the term *object* is used in the same sense that social psychology uses the term *attitude object*, the thing that one has an opinion about. The idea of salience transfer from one agenda to another can be investigated for any set of objects that is of interest. In terms of Lippmann's phrase, "the pictures in our heads," the first level of agenda setting asks, "What are the pictures about?" Many issues, candidates, and other objects compete for our attention, but only a few are in the pictures in our heads.

There is a theoretical advantage in defining basic agenda-setting effects, the first level of agenda setting, as the *transfer of object salience* from one agenda to another because objects have attributes. When political campaigns, news media, or members of the public talk about an object, be it a candidate, issue, or whatever, they almost always say something about the characteristics of that object. Some of these characteristics are emphasized. Others are mentioned less often, and many not at all. For each object there is an agenda of attributes. Again, these attributes can be rank ordered. Which is mentioned the most? Which second most? And so on. The second level of agenda setting, attribute agenda setting, is about the salience of attributes and the *transfer of attribute salience* from one agenda to another.

Images of political leaders provide good examples of attribute agenda setting (McCombs 2014). In the 1994 mayoral election in Taipei, Taiwan, the correlations ranged from 0.59 to 0.78 for six comparisons between voters' images of the three candidates (their public attribute agendas) and news coverage of these attributes (the attribute agendas in two major daily newspapers). Here the *substantive attributes* of these candidates included personal qualities, such as ability, experience, and political style, as well as nonpolitical attributes, such as personality, integrity, and speaking ability.

Beyond the substantive attributes of a candidate or other object in the news—the specific traits or characteristics that describe the object of attention—there

is a second dimension of the attribute agenda, the *affective tone* associated with each substantive attribute. When the media and the public describe an object in terms of its substantive attributes, these attributes can be presented in positive, negative, or neutral terms.

An analysis of the 1996 Spanish general election examined the media and public attribute agendas on which the substantive and affective dimensions were combined for three candidates (McCombs, Lopez-Escobar, and Llamas 2000). The combination of five substantive attributes and three levels of affect produced an attribute agenda with 15 items. For six comparisons of the voters' attribute agendas for each of the three candidates with the attribute agendas of two local newspapers, the median correlation was 0.70. For six comparisons with two national newspapers, the median correlation was 0.81. And for six comparisons with two national TV channels, it was 0.52.

Attribute agenda setting also occurs with public issues (McCombs 2014). Some aspects of issues are emphasized in the news and in how people think about and talk about issues. Other aspects are less salient. During a three-week period prior to a local tax election in Texas, the correspondence between the voters' attribute agenda—the salience of various aspects of the tax issue—and the local newspaper's coverage of various aspects of the local tax increased from 0.40 to 0.65. The public's match with the political advertising on the issue increased from 0.80 to 0.95. A longitudinal study of a Swiss referendum on changing the country's political asylum law also found strong attribute agenda-setting effects evolving among persons reporting heavy reliance on newspapers and TV for public affairs information (Wirth et al. 2010). By the third wave of interviewing, the match between the media's attribute agenda and the public's attribute agenda was 0.92. The news media can have a significant influence on both object salience and attribute salience.

Agenda-setting research at both the first and second levels assumes that the salience of objects and their attributes are transferred *discretely* as individual elements from one agenda to another. However, a new perspective on agenda-setting effects, the Network Agenda Setting Model (NAS), theorizes that objects or attributes can also be transferred simultaneously in bundles from one agenda to another. As Guo (2013) argued, not only can the news media tell us what to think about and how to think about it, they are also capable of telling us how to associate elements with each other. The NAS model introduces a third level of agenda setting by suggesting that the *salience of interrelationships* between issues or attributes also can be transferred between pairs of agendas. This is a broader and more comprehensive, as well as more powerful, hypothesis about media effects than traditional first- and second-level agenda-setting hypotheses, which are focused on the salience of discrete objects and attributes.

This focus on bundles of message elements provides a more nuanced understanding of the “pictures in our heads.” In addition, the NAS model provides a new methodological approach that employs social network analysis to examine network relationships among objects or attributes on the media and public agenda and then compares the two (Guo 2012).

In their initial empirical investigation of the NAS Model, Guo and McCombs (2011) reanalyzed the data originally collected for Kim and McCombs’ (2007) second-level study of attribute agenda-setting effects. These data detail the media and public attribute agendas of the Republican and Democrat candidates in 2002 for Texas governor and U.S. senator from Texas. Specifically, these data examined attributes concerning candidate qualifications and character, which were the most prominent attributes highlighted by the *Austin, Texas*, daily newspaper and by Austin voters. The results from the traditional analysis of these data by Kim and McCombs provided a benchmark for evaluating the strength of networked agenda setting.

The goal of the network analysis used to test the NAS model was to map the network of relationships among these candidate attributes both on the media agenda and the public agenda. The unit of analysis is a dyad: a pair of attributes and the frequency of their co-occurrence in the news stories of the *Austin American-Statesman* (the media attribute agenda) or in citizens’ responses to the survey question, “Suppose that one of your friends has been away a long time and knows nothing about the political candidates. What would you tell your friend about (name of a candidate)?” (The public attribute agenda). The more frequently each pair of attributes co-occurred across news articles or across respondents’ descriptions of the candidates, the stronger their networked relationship.

The results for the network agenda-setting analysis are similar to the strength of the attribute agenda-setting effects found by Kim and McCombs. The rank-order correlation coefficient (*Spearman’s rho* = 0.65) between the media and public attribute agendas reported by Kim and McCombs is essentially identical to the network correlation (*Pearson’s r* = +0.67) between the media and public network attribute agendas. Although the two analyses—one based on the use of discrete attributes and the new analysis based on networked attributes—are statistically similar, figures 4.1 and 4.2, which present the networked results graphically, demonstrate the qualitative richness of the third level of agenda-setting effects. Here we can see not only which attributes are most prominent in the media and among the public, but we also see the relationships among these attributes in great detail. In terms of Lippmann’s phrase, “the pictures in our heads,” we come much closer to seeing actual pictures. In sum, agenda-setting effects can be examined in terms of the transfer of salience from one agenda to another at three levels: agendas of objects, attributes, and networks.

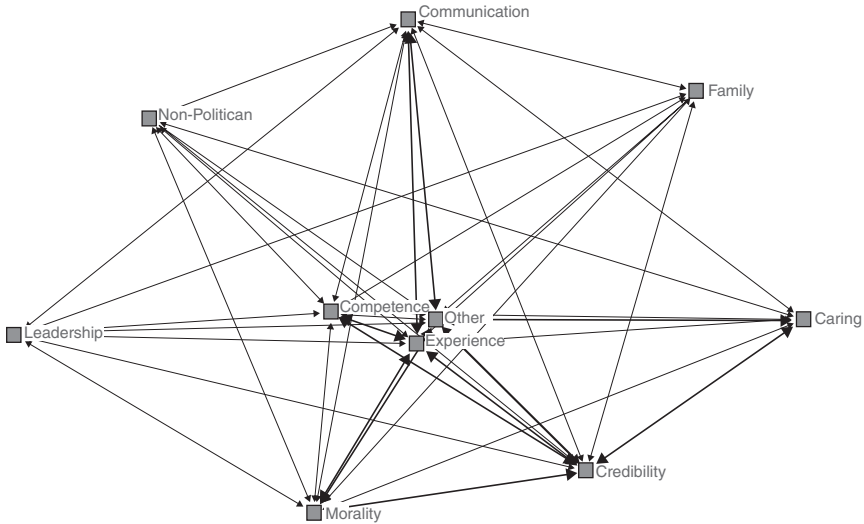


FIGURE 4.1 Media Attribute Agenda

Source: Guo & McCombs, 2011.

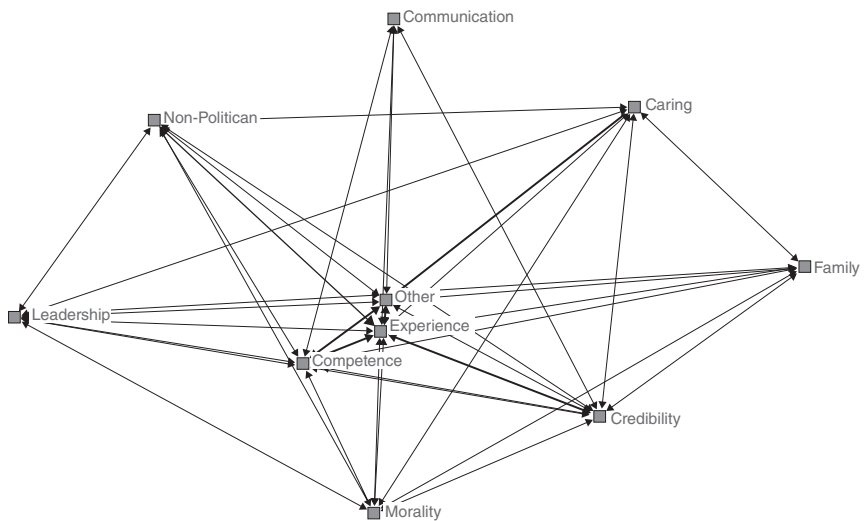


FIGURE 4.2 Public Attribute Agenda

Source: Guo & McCombs, 2011.

Electoral Consequences of Agenda Setting

What are the likely political implications of media agenda setting in major elections? Voters' issue awareness may have a considerable impact on electoral choices because voters are usually able to identify a party or a candidate as the best handler of an issue (RePass 1971). Over time, citizens internalize

persistent perceptions of political parties' issue-handling or problem-solving capability, perceptions that Petrocik (1996) terms "partisan issue ownership." In a similar context, Budge and Farlie (1983) point out that a party that owns more salient issues may win over more swing voters in a two-party system. As Brosius and Kepplinger (1992) demonstrate, issue-agenda balance in the news media can directly influence party preference. For example, when there was intensive reporting on environmental issues, people's preference for the Green Party increased. On the other hand, when a considerable amount of news coverage reported on defense and national security, public support for the conservative Christian Democratic Party rose. Lewis-Beck and Rice (1992) indicate that the salience of economic concerns or a wide array of social issues, such as education, health care, social security, and so on, may influence the direction of voting. For that reason, political contenders seek to dominate the news agenda with issues for which they are perceived as more competent than their rivals.

Media agenda setting also indirectly influences political attitudes and behavior (Balmas and Sheafer 2010; Kioussis 2005; Kuklinski and Quark 2000; McCombs 2004; Moon 2013). The notion of priming has persuasively been used to address the political consequences of agenda setting, suggesting that the news media can influence the way people evaluate politicians by making certain issues salient (Iyengar and Kinder 1987; Iyengar, Peters, and Kinder 1982; Krosnick and Kinder 1990). That is, the media's emphasis on a certain issue temporarily heightens its accessibility and activates relevant attitudes closely linked to that issue in an individual's memory. Those attitudes, in turn, play a critical role in the evaluation of political figures, especially political candidates vying for office.

Similarly, the concept of attribute priming captures the consequences of attribute agenda setting. Media attention to a candidate's specific attributes can influence voters' candidate perception and, further, their candidate evaluation and vote choice (Balmas and Sheafer 2010; Kim and McCombs 2007; Kim, Scheufele, and Shanahan 2002; Kioussis et al. 2006). In other words, the media may prominently establish certain substantive attributes regarding a candidate in a voter's mind, so the voter becomes more likely to consider those attributes when evaluating the candidate (Sheafer 2007). The affective component of news coverage, that is, the evaluative tone of news stories about a candidate, can also color the audience's evaluation. In sum, campaign news can semantically prime certain aspects of candidate images while eliciting affective reactions to those aspects through its evaluative tones. In Balmas and Sheafer's study (2010), the tone of the most accessible attributes regarding a candidate (e.g., strong leadership, lack of morality, lack of credibility, integrity, etc.) significantly predicted Israeli voters' evaluation of a candidate's suitability for prime minister and their voting intention for the candidate's political party.

In essence, the notion of agenda setting encapsulates the media's power to focus public attention on certain aspects of reality. By so doing, the media tell the public what they need to think about and form their own opinions on. Public attention to certain issues usually leads to in-depth thinking and active learning about those matters and, consequently, results in robust attitudes toward the issues. According to Kioussis and McCombs (2004), more frequent media attention to certain political candidates in the 1996 presidential election led to higher salience of those figures and, further, stronger attitudes in voters' minds toward those candidates. Moon (2013) substantiates that relationship in the 2004 presidential election, finding that the electoral news not only influenced how voters thought about major candidates (i.e., the elevated prominence of certain candidate attributes) but also resulted in more intensive attitudes toward those candidates. Moon further addresses a behavioral consequence of this chain of agenda-setting effects. Specifically, stronger attitudes led to more active political participation, such as voting, indicating that the media can indirectly facilitate political participation through the second level of agenda setting.

In summary, the prominence of certain elements in the news—objects and their cognitive and affective attributes—translates into accessible and applicable cues in an individual's memory, cues that can be easily retrieved at the time of making judgments, such as deciding whom to vote for.

Agenda Setting in the Politics 2.0 Age

New digital communication technologies have significantly transformed political campaigns. Among others, the place of social media in the campaign-media mix has become more central, leading, for example, to President Obama's successful use of social media in the 2008 election (Enli and Moe 2013). More than any other age group, young adults tend to use social media to acquire political information and actively express their political opinions (Kushin and Yamamoto 2010), explaining why Obama's social media campaigns primarily targeted that age group.

Social media also function as a significant platform where voters talk about their ballot selections and encourage others to vote. In the 2012 presidential election, around 30 percent of registered voters were encouraged to vote for either candidate by family or friends via social media, such as Facebook or Twitter. About 20 percent of registered voters tried to convince others to vote by posting on a social networking site (Rainie 2012). Overall, the number of social-networking site users grew from 33 percent of the online population in 2008 to 69 percent of the online population in 2012 (Smith 2013); thus, we assume the influence of social media will continue to expand across all age groups in future political campaigns.

New digital media, including social media, are well-known for reinforcing politically motivated selective exposure (Stroud 2011). Nowadays, people have available an unprecedented array of choices. They can selectively approach (or selectively avoid) what they want (or do not want) to read, hear, and watch. Media users construct their own media mix so that the chances of inadvertent exposure and by-product learning have decreased. The burgeoning diversification of media outlets and contents, accompanied by the segmentation of audience members, may further weaken the agenda-setting power of the national elite media (Bennett and Iyengar 2008; Chaffee and Metzger 2001; Stroud 2011). This rapidly changing media landscape has led several scholars to argue that there are no longer large-scale media effects (Bennett and Iyengar 2008, 2010), posing a challenge for agenda-setting theory that was developed when the mainstream media held a dominant status in defining reality (Takeshita 2006).

However, this impact has not yet appeared in recent longitudinal studies of mainstream media agenda setting. Tan and Weaver (2013, 10) “did not find that the agenda-setting effect between the *New York Times* and public opinion has become weaker over time. Regardless of the plethora of media outlets in the new media environment, the diversification of media has not decreased the *New York Times*’ influence on public consensus on the most important issues in society.” In their analysis of agenda-setting effects from 1968 to 2004, Lee and Coleman (2014) found median correlations of 0.68 for the civic generation, 0.57 for baby boomers, and 0.74 for the youngest generation, respectively, with the *New York Times*.¹ Neither study found evidence of a downward trend in agenda-setting effects over time. In their analysis of the news choices of journalists and consumers in six mainstream American news sites, Boczkowski, Mitchelstein, and Walter (2012) also suggest that the media may retain a strong agenda-setting effect, especially during periods of heightened political activity such as election campaigns.

Meanwhile, in the United States, prior research has shown that traditional and online news agendas reciprocally influence each other. Some studies have demonstrated that traditional news entities and online news sites provide highly homogenous agendas of topics. For instance, Lee (2007) showed that the mainstream news and online blog agendas significantly converged in the 2004 presidential election, although it was not clear which media led that merging. Similarly, Wallsten (2007) demonstrated a complex, bidirectional relationship between the media and blog agendas of 35 issues during the 2004 presidential campaign.

Some studies have suggested that political bloggers are likely to follow news coverage rather than vice versa. Cornfield et al. (2005) found a strong rank-order correlation between traditional news and blog contents, with traditional media exerting slightly greater influence on blogs (0.78) than vice

versa (0.65) during the last two months of the 2004 presidential campaign. Heim (2013) also reports that the news and campaign media had a significant second-level agenda-setting effect on nine prominent political blogs in the 2008 Democratic presidential primaries; political bloggers, regardless of their partisan leaning, largely followed the agenda of candidate attributes constructed by mainstream journalists. In Meraz's (2009) study, the *New York Times* and the *Washington Post* appeared to be particularly influential, maintaining their elite status as agenda setters within the independent political blog networks.

Other studies, in contrast, have proposed that the blog agenda may exert a stronger influence on mainstream media coverage (Woodly 2008). Although blog users are relatively small in number, they are very likely to be active opinion leaders (Baum and Groeling 2008), indicating the growing importance of independent political blogs in the process of agenda setting and public opinion formation. As Drezner and Farrell (2004) point out, journalists often take cues of issue importance from Weblogs; under certain circumstances, key Weblogs can successfully set new or neglected issues for the mainstream media agenda, provoking national debates on those issues.

According to Meraz (2009), "The independent blog platform is redistributing power between traditional media and citizen media . . . utilizing the blog tool to allow citizens more influence and power in setting news agendas" (701). That is, the possibility of reversed agenda setting by which ordinary citizens set an issue for the news media can be augmented in the technological and cultural contexts of contemporary political communication. The Internet offers interested citizens convenient and alternative ways to contact political candidates and campaigns as well as to voice their own issue priorities to the media (Woodly 2008). Ways for individuals or small groups to play a role as agenda setters for the traditional media or the political sector appear virtually unlimited. This may be especially so during election periods when citizens' political interest is heightened.

In conclusion, we are observing a proliferation of more numerous as well as more meaningful opportunities for multiple players to contribute to the field of agenda setting in the politics 2.0 age. Certainly, the overall landscape of electoral communication is rapidly changing, but not yet to an extent that overtakes the powerful role played by the traditional news media in terms of agenda setting and its effects on the public.

Note

1. The authors calculated *Spearman's rho* correlations between the media and public agendas in nine different years from 1968 to 2004 for the civic generation and for baby boomers and in five years from 1986 to 2004 for the youngest generation.

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